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### **National Security in an Evolving Threat Environment**

National security today extends far beyond traditional military defense. The greatest threats facing the United States are hybrid and interconnected, blending cyber, environmental, economic, and ideological elements. Among these are cybersecurity vulnerabilities, domestic extremism, and climate-related instability, which stand out as the most pressing challenges. These threats span digital, political, and environmental domains, making them difficult to manage through traditional deterrence or intelligence strategies. As globalization continues to erode state boundaries, national defense increasingly depends on cooperation across governments, private sectors, and international partners (Sterio, 2005).

Cybersecurity remains one of the most immediate and evolving threats. The nation's growing reliance on digital networks across communication, energy, transportation, and finance has made it increasingly susceptible to cyberattacks. Global connectivity enables both state and non-state actors to disrupt essential systems and weaponize information (Hough, 2023). The 2021 Colonial Pipeline ransomware attack showed how a single intrusion could ripple through energy supply chains and public confidence, demonstrating that cybersecurity is no longer just an IT issue but a fundamental pillar of national defense. At the same time, domestic extremism has become a persistent internal threat. The Department of Homeland Security continues to identify racially or ethnically motivated violent extremists as among the most lethal dangers to the homeland (U.S. Department of Homeland Security, 2023). The January 6th attack on the U.S.

Capitol revealed how online radicalization and disinformation can escalate into real-world violence, showing that internal division can be as destabilizing as foreign aggression.

Equally significant are climate-related security threats, which act as threat multipliers by amplifying social and political instability. Environmental shocks such as hurricanes, droughts, and wildfires displace populations, damage infrastructure, and strain government resources all of which can be exploited by hostile actors (Hough, 2023). Events like Hurricane Katrina highlight how large-scale disasters can expose weaknesses in coordination and emergency response. As climate change increases both the frequency and intensity of these disasters, environmental resilience must become central to any security strategy.

When evaluating how prepared the national security apparatus is to handle these challenges, the United States demonstrates both strengths and weaknesses. Agencies such as the National Security Agency, Cyber Command, and the Department of Homeland Security have made major strides toward integrating cyber defense and intelligence sharing. While the establishment of the Cybersecurity and Infrastructure Security Agency shows growing recognition of public-private collaboration. Yet, the national security approach often reflects global trends, shifting from long term state building to short term stabilization. An evolution that can limit strategic depth and preparedness (Clausen & Albrecht, 2015). Bureaucratic overlap, slow policy adaptation, budget cutting and fragmented information sharing continue to hinder effective coordination. Despite strong technological and intelligence capabilities, the U.S. still lags in anticipatory planning, which is essential in today's rapidly evolving threat landscape (Hough, 2023).

In reflection, the United States faces a multifaceted security environment where the lines between domestic and foreign threats are increasingly blurred. Cyber vulnerabilities, ideological

extremism, and environmental instability are interconnected risks that demand rapid response, collaboration, and resilience rather than traditional defense postures. While the nation has made meaningful progress, lasting security will depend on its ability to adapt quickly, modernize institutions, and rebuild public trust. True preparedness in the 21<sup>st</sup> century rests not only on military strength, but on societal unity and the collective will to confront complex global challenges (Hough, 2023).

## References

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